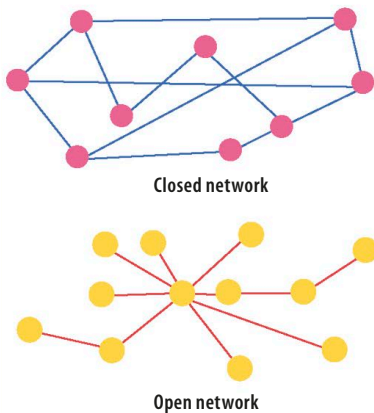


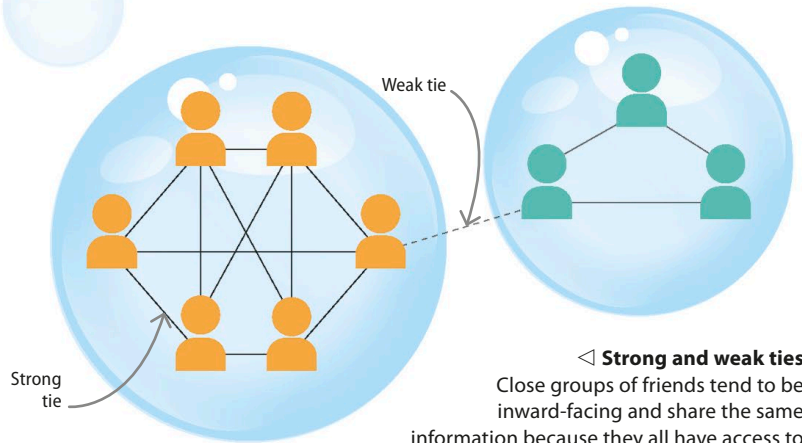
## IN DEPTH

**Closed and open networks**

There are two kinds of social network - open and closed. An example of an open network is Twitter: you can connect with anyone you want to, and they don't have to connect back to you to make the friendship official. But in closed networks, like Facebook, you have to reciprocate an invitation to be a friend before you are connected and can access all their information.

**How bubbles are created**

A social media platform's main aim is to keep as many users interacting with their service as possible. Social media's main revenue comes from showing users advertisements, and the longer users are on the site, the more adverts they will see. The best way to keep you focused on something is to confirm your biases, because it feels good. Social media feeds users things they want to see through complex algorithms. These algorithms guess what a user will like based on what they have expressed a like for before, and also what their friends like.

**Strong and weak ties**

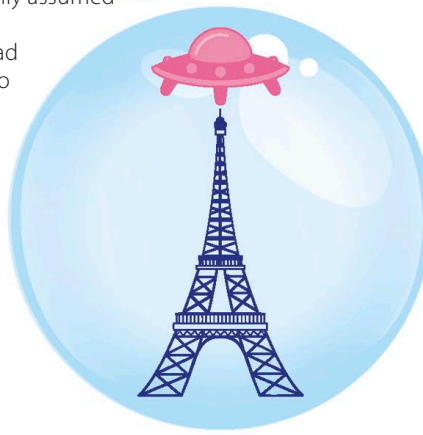
Close groups of friends tend to be inward-facing and share the same information because they all have access to the same sources: each other. Weak ties are important as they are an opportunity for a user to be exposed to different points of view.

**Fake news**

Since people confirm their biases online through their social networks, it's easy to create a story or opinion that will resonate with a particular set of people, even if it's untrue. All it needs to do is use the generally assumed beliefs of one group and extend them in a believable way. This can then quickly spread as people with similar beliefs will share it to prove themselves right. The more people share it, the more it's believed to be true. Also, people can claim that something is fake news when it isn't, purely because they don't agree with it.

**Eiffel abduction**

A fake news report might say that a UFO has abducted the Eiffel Tower in Paris, France. Cross-checking the story with other news sites is advised before believing it!



## REAL WORLD

**Filtered reality**

During the 2004 US presidential election, American scientist Lada Adamic wanted to find out how much people on opposite sides of the political spectrum interacted with each other online. What she found was that each side tended to listen to only their own side's points of view, and there were very few people who took the time and effort to listen to and understand the views of others. This results in a polarization of opinions, where each side becomes increasingly more opposed to the other's political views, making it harder for people to trust each other, and harder for politicians to reach agreement.